

World in Brief: Iran's plan for Hormuz; Trump targets birthright citizenship again



Photograph: Anadolu via Getty Images

Iran's parliament is reviewing a draft plan to reopen the **Strait of Hormuz**, according to Fars, an Iranian news site. The proposal reportedly includes banning vessels from America, Israel and “hostile” countries from transiting [the waterway](#), and imposing fines of up to 20% of a ship's cargo value on those who violate Iran's rules. Oil prices rose slightly on the news.

Donald Trump signed two executive orders targeting **birthright citizenship**, weeks after the Supreme Court struck down [his previous attempt to overturn it](#). One expands the definition of ineligible parents to “any member of a designated Foreign Terrorist Organisation”. The other seeks to end “birth tourism”, which involves travelling to America solely to have a child. Both will probably be challenged in court.

EasyJet accepted a £5.7bn (\$7.7bn) [takeover offer](#) from **Apollo**, an American investment firm. Earlier **Castlelake**, a rival suitor, said it had abandoned its bid to buy the European budget airline. Unlike Castlelake, which probably wanted to sell easyJet for parts, Apollo had pledged to double-down on the airline's plans to upgrade planes and expand its holiday packages.

A Senate committee voted to hold **Anthony Fauci** in contempt of Congress, after he repeatedly refused to answer questions about his handling of [the covid-19 pandemic](#) during a recent hearing with lawmakers. Dr Fauci was formerly a chief medical adviser to the White House. Before leaving office, Joe Biden gave him a pre-emptive pardon. It is unclear if America's Justice Department will choose to prosecute him.

Diageo's boss set out a plan to perk up the struggling British **booze-maker**. "Drastic Dave" Lewis (a nickname he earned as a director at Unilever, a consumer-goods conglomerate) aims to save \$1bn over three years, largely through job cuts. Diageo, which makes [Guinness](#) and Smirnoff vodka, reported a 2% drop in organic sales for the 12 months to the end of June, compared with a year earlier.

Scientists at Stanford University said they used **AI** to engineer novel **viruses**. The researchers created a generative **AI** model, trained it on genetic sequences, then asked it to write new ones capable of fighting the bacteria *E. coli*. The model created 16 "exceptional" phages, which are viruses that can infect bacteria. While celebrating the model's benefits, the scientists acknowledged that it raised ["biosecurity considerations"](#).

FIFA's management board voted to keep **Gianni Infantino** as the federation's boss at a crisis meeting in Morocco. Earlier he apologised to its 211 member-associations for "errors" in his [aborted plan](#) to sell stakes in football tournaments to private investors. **UEFA**, the European football body, said it would conduct an independent valuation of **FIFA's** commercial assets amid suspicions that Mr Infantino's proposal undervalued them.

Figure of the day: 2,000. The number of padel courts in Britain. Back in 2020, there were just 87. Millions now play padel around the world. [Read our story about whether anyone will watch it.](#)

US in Brief: The left's hot streak



Photograph: AP

Republicans attacked the candidacy of **Abdul El-Sayed** after the progressive Democrat won Michigan's Senate primary. J.D. Vance, the vice-president, said he would only appeal to "wealthy white liberals" and criticised his policies on immigration, which include calls to abolish Immigration and Customs Enforcement. The former public-health official narrowly beat Haley Stevens, a more moderate congresswoman, in a [bitter intraparty struggle](#). His win added to the [left's momentum](#) following other primary victories in New York City and Colorado.

Chuck Edwards, a Republican congressman from **North Carolina**, withdrew his campaign for re-election in November's midterms. On Sunday the Ethics Committee of the House of Representatives recommended Mr Edwards be censured after finding that he engaged in "persistent unprofessional and inappropriate conduct" towards young female staff. He denies wrongdoing. The party will reportedly decide on a replacement candidate next week.

The Senate voted 51-44 to confirm **Dr Erica Schwartz** to lead the Centres for Disease Control and Prevention. Only one Democrat, Tim Kaine, supported her nomination. Dr Schwartz, who served as deputy surgeon general during Donald Trump's first term, has voiced support for childhood vaccines. That contrasts with the

[vaccine scepticism](#) of Robert F. Kennedy junior, the health secretary. The CDC is grappling with several public-health crises, including the spread of cyclosporiasis, an intestinal parasite.

New Mexico sued the Department of Justice, demanding it hand over evidence from its investigation into crimes committed by **Jeffrey Epstein**. New Mexico's attorney-general claimed the department is "stonewalling" attempts to identify more of the [dead sex offender's](#) victims by refusing to pass on unredacted files about crimes committed at his ranch in the state. The DOJ said it is not obliged to make "such sweeping disclosures".

A federal judge in **Texas** overturned a longstanding gun-control law, calling it unconstitutional. The law required gun owners to acquire a permit for certain short-barrelled weapons and equipment, including silencers. The judge ruled that, because Congress voted to remove a \$200 tax on the permits last year, it no longer had the authority to impose the regulation. He gave the DOJ a week to appeal.

A federal judge confirmed that the rights for hundreds of thousands of **Haitians** to live and work in America had officially ended. In June the Supreme Court ruled that the administration could scrap Temporary Protected Status for Haitians and Syrians. The government is also pushing to remove protections for people from other countries affected by conflict. The Supreme Court's ruling makes it less likely that legal attempts to preserve them will succeed.

Frustrating forecasts from the Fed



Photograph: Reuters

Kevin Warsh’s press conference last week rattled markets. The Federal Reserve’s new chair dodged questions and revealed little about how he reads the economy. He lobbed in confusing metaphors such as “market participants are learning to play the ball, not the referee.” Afterwards, long-term bond yields rose while short-term yields fell—a sign that investors expect easier policy soon, but greater inflation risks later.

Other Fed officials will now try to clarify the message. On Thursday Alberto Musalem, president of the St Louis Fed, will discuss America’s monetary-policy outlook at a Brazilian think-tank. On Friday his counterpart at the Richmond Fed, Thomas Barkin, will have a cosy “fireside chat” with the National Association for Business Economics. Last weekend Mr Musalem said that he “took [a] signal” from Mr Warsh’s comments: “that we need to continue to earn our credibility every day with both effective communication and actions”. With labour-market risks receding and core inflation still above 3%, one action may be a rate rise in September.

Warner Bros Discovery is in limbo



Photograph: AFP

With its [\\$111bn sale](#) to Paramount stalled, Warner Bros Discovery is expected to report weak second-quarter results on Thursday. It has had few recent box-office hits and its cable business is moribund. A sharp decline in revenues year on year has probably pushed WBD into the red. The sole bright spot is its streaming service: HBO Max is heading towards 150m global subscribers this year. From September 30th shareholders can also look forward to a \$650m-a-quarter “ticking fee” from Paramount (a penalty paid when a transaction is delayed). That will persist until there is resolution to the [antitrust fight](#) between Paramount, led by David Ellison, and 12 states’ attorneys-general.

The trial has been set for March. In the meantime, a question mark hangs over the future of WBD’s news outlet. Mr Ellison’s critics argue that CNN would shift to the right under his control, which the Trump-aligned billionaire disputes. The drama is gripping.

Britain's housing pledge is on shaky foundations



Photograph: David Simonds

Cracks in Britain's housing market are widening. War in Iran has kept inflation up, raising interest rates and hurting demand. Higher construction costs have also slowed building. Britain's largest residential developers issued eight profit warnings in the first half of 2026, recalling the global financial crisis of 2007-09. On Thursday Persimmon, one of Britain's biggest housebuilders, defied the slowdown, reporting a 15% growth year on year in first-half profits and 13% growth completions. But, despite success in controlling rising costs, it warned of a "challenging" market.

But Vistry, another developer, has suffered most. Its stock has fallen by 60% since the war began, and is now Britain's most shorted. In 2023 it switched from focusing on private sales to [state-subsidised housing](#). Still, the firm sold just 6,100 homes in the first half of this year, down by 11% from the same period in 2025. In part because of the difficulties faced by homebuilders, the government's pledge of 1.5m new homes before the next general election, due by 2029, looks unattainable. Targets, ministers are finding, are easier to lay than bricks.

Will Japan's non-nuclear pledge survive?



Photograph: Reuters

On Thursday Japan observed the 81st anniversary of the [atomic bombing of Hiroshima](#). At a ceremony, the mayor read out a customary declaration calling for “the immediate abolition of nuclear weapons”.

Since 1967 Japan has pledged not to produce, possess or host nukes. But its pacifist ideals are under strain. The government is reviewing its main defence policies and considering whether to revise its non-nuclear principles in the face of an unstable world order. Takaichi Sanae, the prime minister, argues that refusing to allow other countries to keep their nuclear weapons on Japanese territory is increasingly unrealistic if the country still wants protection from America’s nuclear umbrella. At the ceremony in Hiroshima, which she attended, she avoided making any clear statement on the issue. Koizumi Shinjiro, her defence minister, recently said it should be debated “without taboos”.

Such remarks have provoked backlash, especially from survivors of the nuclear bombings. One poll suggests 75% of Japanese prefer the status quo. But the fact that politicians are even suggesting a change shows how the mood in Japan is shifting.

Daily quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Thursday: What suffix is used in taxonomy to refer to feet?

Wednesday: Which TV series featured Scott Bakula playing the time-travelling scientist, Sam Beckett?

*The secret of staying young is to
live honestly, eat slowly and lie
about your age.*

Lucille Ball